

General Anaesthetic for Caesarean Birth – Labourpains.org patient information leaflet

What is a general anaesthetic?

Most caesarean births are done with you awake but under regional anaesthesia. A general anaesthetic means giving you medicines to make you sleep (unconscious). This means you are not awake and do not feel pain during the operation.

Why might I need a general anaesthetic for caesarean birth?

Some people choose to have a general anaesthetic.

Or, you may need one if:

- You need a caesarean very urgently and there is no time for a spinal or epidural anaesthetic to work.
- You have certain conditions when the blood doesn't clot properly. This may make it unsafe to have a spinal or epidural anaesthetic.
- Abnormalities in your back may make regional anaesthetic difficult or impossible.
- Occasionally, a spinal or epidural anaesthetic can't be put in the right place or doesn't work properly.

What happens when you have a general anaesthetic?

You will have a small tube called a cannula ('drip') placed in your arm.

You may be given an antacid medicine. This is to prevent acid in your stomach from passing to your lungs when you are asleep.

In the operating theatre, you will be given oxygen through a facemask. You will have a urinary catheter (tube) placed in your bladder.

The obstetricians will clean your tummy. This is so they can deliver your baby as soon as you are asleep. The anaesthetic doctor will give medicine in your cannula that slowly sends you to sleep.

As you fall asleep, you may feel pressure on your neck. This is to avoid any acid in your stomach going into your airway.

Once asleep, the obstetricians will deliver your baby and placenta. You will be given painkillers while you are asleep. You may also be given local anaesthetic injections into your tummy to help with pain relief.

Once the operation is complete, you will be woken up.

Will my birth partner be with me if I have a general anaesthetic?

Your birth partner will not be able to be with you during the operation, but they will be nearby. The team will update them once your baby is born. They can join you in the recovery area when you are awake.

What happens to my baby after it is born if I am asleep?

A member of the neonatal team will be present at birth. The midwife will dry your baby and check them over. If your baby is well, they will be looked after by your midwife until you are awake. Sometimes, babies may need some extra support with their breathing. If that is the case, they will be looked after by the neonatal team.

What happens when I wake up?

When you wake up, you may feel quite sleepy. Some pain after the operation is normal. You may feel sickly. Painkillers and anti-sickness medication will be available if you need them.

Are there any risks of general anaesthetic?

In the United Kingdom, around 15,000 patients have a caesarean birth under general anaesthesia each year. The majority of these are very straightforward. However, there are some risks and side effects of general anaesthetics.

Very common or common

Sore throat: 1 in 2

Shivering: 1 in 3

Feeling and being sick: 1 in 10

Uncommon or rare

Accidental awareness under general anaesthetic (accidental awareness (when someone has memories of events in the operating theatre when they should have been asleep. Most patients are accidentally aware do not feel pain): 1 in 212 to 1 in 670

Stomach acid going into the lungs: 1 in 1000

Scratch or damage to the eye: 1 in 1,000

Teeth damage: 1 in 4,500

Very Rare

Severe allergic reactions 1 in 10,000

Brain damage or death caused directly by anaesthesia is extremely rare: 1 in 100,000 or even less.